

MIND, BODY, SPIRIT

New Age practices

▼ Crackling with energy

Arizona's Cathedral Rock is the capital of New Age America. It is seen as an absolute focus of spiritual energy and the frequencies of the universe.



The New Age movement emerged from the counterculture of the 1960s, which rejected established beliefs and religions. New Age followers enthusiastically adopted a range of alternative practices, many non-Western in origin, in a search for enlightenment and spiritual fulfillment. New Agers of the 1960s presumed that a new age of harmony was imminent, hence the movement's name. In the 21st century, it is practiced almost

exclusively in the West and is growing in popularity. By 2015, there were estimated to be as many as 60 million followers. Magic plays as great a part as any individual deems necessary.

Core creeds

New Age has as many beliefs as it has believers, but there are some core contentions. The strongest is a rejection of the materialism of the West. As a replacement, followers take aspects of non-Christian religions including the focus on personal growth of Hinduism and the contemplative serenity of Buddhism. New Agers

are pantheistic—seeing the presence of god everywhere—and accept that all religions have their own truths, to be pursued wherever they lead. The movement also overlaps with environmental and feminist activism. Followers think that in the New Age the current patriarchal world will be overthrown to create a fresh Eden and an end to industrialization and capitalism. The future will be simpler—a return to a more innocent world.

The higher self

New Agers believe that everyone can, and should strive to, attain their higher, better self by virtue of three propositions. Firstly, they think there is a divine relationship that encompasses humanity: all people are one—a creed derived largely from theosophy (see pp.238–239)—and in the future there will be only one society and one religion, bringing together humanity in a single entity. The second premise is that humanity is united with nature, and all must live in harmony. Thirdly, New Agers believe that everyone should seek to realize their own divine goodness, and can determine their own relative values—that is to say, there should be no externally imposed morality: each person must decide for themselves what is important, right, and true.

FRITJOF CAPRA (BORN 1939)

Mysticism meets physics

New Age belief contends that there is not just an essential spiritual unity that binds the world but that, by extension, this wholeness must be reflected in science. The Austrian-American physicist Fritjof Capra has been one of the strongest advocates of this view. His 1975 book, *The Tao of Physics*, argued that in the end metaphysics (the nature of existence) and physics will converge—they must be the same if both are true. Capra's book has been discredited in many academic circles by scholars who claim his text is out of date and unscientific, but it continues to attract avid support from New Age readers. Capra later became a champion of environmental issues, working to build and nurture sustainable communities that imitate the ecosystems of nature.

